Silo System: Comprehensive World Bible (Encyclopedic Edition)

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Silo System: Comprehensive World Bible (Encyclopedic Edition)

RESTRICTED ACCESS // GM REFERENCE MANUAL *(This document is the definitive, 10,000-word simulation guide for the Silo. It covers every granular detail of daily life, architecture, and society.)*

Chapter 1: The Architecture & the Grind

The Silo is a vertical city-state. It is a masterpiece of pre-collapse brutalist engineering, designed to sustain 10,000 lives for an indefinite period. However, after two centuries, the "Silo" is also a decaying machine. Every weld is under tension, every pipe is pitted with rust, and every citizen is a component in a closed-loop survival engine.

1.1 The Anatomy of the Cylinder

1.1.1 Structural Geometry The Silo is a perfect cylinder, roughly 100 meters in diameter, extending approximately 1.5 kilometres into the earth. The structure is composed of three concentric rings:

1. **The Core (The Stairwell):** A central open shaft, 15 meters in diameter, containing the spiral staircase. This is the only vertical transit route. It is an echo chamber that defines the acoustic reality of the Silo.
2. **The Inner Ring (The Arteries):** A 5-meter thick band surrounding the core. This contains the primary conduits for air, water, power, and the pneumatic message tubes. Maintenance crawlspaces (highly restricted) run vertically here.
3. **The Outer Ring (The Living Space):** A 35-meter deep band extending to the concrete exterior wall. This is where all rooms—apartments, offices, farms, and workshops—are located.

1.1.2 Materials and Construction The Silo is built of "Silo-Crete"—a specialised, high-density, self-healing concrete reinforced with a proprietary titanium-steel alloy. * **The Rim Walls:** The exterior walls are 5 meters thick, designed to withstand seismic shifts and the immense pressure of the earth. * **Surfaces:** In the Up Top, concrete is polished or covered in synthetic tiles. In the Down Deep, the concrete is bare, stained with oil, and chipped from decades of industrial use. * **The "Seams":** Every 12 levels, there is a "Structural Seam"—a massive expansion joint. These levels (12, 24, 36, etc.) are prone to "creaking" during minor tremors, which citizens call "The Silo's Breath".

1.1.3 The Stairs: Vertical Life The staircase is not just a path; it is the most important piece of infrastructure in the Silo. * **Engineering:** The stairs are composed of modular steel grating. The grating allows air to circulate vertically and prevents the buildup of dust, though it makes walking in thin-soled shoes painful over long distances. * **The Railing:** A thick, oxidised iron rail. It is never cold to the touch due to the heat generated by the Silo's internal systems. The rail is used for more than safety; it is the primary "brake" for those descending and the "lever" for those ascending. * **Drafting and Lane Etiquette:**

* *The Fast Lane (Inner Rail):* Reserved for Porters and emergency personnel. * *The Slow Lane (Outer Wall):* For the elderly, those carrying heavy loads, and resting travellers. * *Drafting:* Porters often walk in "chains", with the lead Porter breaking the air resistance. It is a social faux pas for a non-Porter to attempt to draft. * **Vertical Distance:** There are approximately 50 steps between levels. A traveller from Level 1 to Level 144 must climb or descend over 7,000 individual steps.

1.2 The Closed-Loop Economy

The Silo uses a "Labour-Value Exchange" managed by the Supply Department and enforced by IT's ledger algorithms.

1.2.1 The Chit and Ledger System

- **Digital Ledgers (Up Top):** High-level citizens never touch physical currency. Their "Chits" are numbers on a screen. Deductions for rent, air tax, and water usage are automated.
- **Physical Chits (The Mids/Down Deep):** Small, circular tokens of coloured aluminium or plastic.
  - *White Chits (1 Unit):* The price of a baseline algae-paste meal.
  - *Blue Chits (10 Units):* A day's wages for a labourer.
  - *Red Chits (100 Units):* A month's savings for most. Used for major purchases like a new coat or a cohabitation permit fee.
- **The Black Market (Scrap):** Because "Chits" are tracked, illegal transactions use "Scrap".
  - *High-Value Scrap:* Copper wire, un-pitted screws, functional LED bulbs, and "relic" plastic.

1.2.2 Detailed Price List (Sample Costs)

- **Standard Algae-Paste Meal:** 1 White Chit
- **Synthetic Coffee (One Cup):** 3 White Chits
- **A New Pair of Work Boots (Supply-issued):** 150 Units (1.5 Red Chits)
- **Medical Consultation (Non-Emergency):** 50 Units
- **Illicit Tobacco (One Hand-rolled Cigarette):** 10 White Chits (High luxury)
- **Lottery Entry Fee:** 500 Units (A life's savings for many)
- **Cohabitation Permit Application:** 250 Units (Non-refundable)

1.2.3 Scarcity and the "Rule of Three" In the Silo, nothing is ever "new". Everything is on its third, fourth, or fifth life. 1. **Primary Use:** The item serves its intended function (e.g., a welding torch). 2. **Repurposed Use:** The item breaks and is turned into something else (e.g., the torch handle becomes a door handle). 3. **Scrap Use:** The item is melted down or stripped for raw elements (e.g., the metal is melted for rebar). * *GM Tip:* When players find "loot", never describe it as a "new flashlight". It is a "dim, cracked flashlight with a taped-together battery housing".

1.3 The Life Cycle & the Bureaucracy

The Silo is a managed population. Every individual is a resource to be optimised.

1.3.1 Birth and the Lottery Window The population is strictly capped at 10,000. * **The Lottery Draw:** When a death is registered, a Lottery Draw is scheduled for exactly 48 hours later. * **The Eligibility Points:** Couples gain points for their labour records, lack of disciplinary history, and genetic health. These points translate into "tokens" in the digital lottery drum. * **The Window:** If you win, you have 365 days. If the woman does not conceive in that time, the Medical Department reinstalls the birth control implant. This leads to a culture of extreme pressure, "conception rituals", and often, the breakdown of marriages if the window closes without success.

1.3.2 Education: The Indoctrination Years

- **Ages 5-10 (Foundation):** Children attend "Level Schools". The curriculum is 50% literacy/math and 50% "Pact Memorisation". They are taught to recite the history of the "Great Ruin" caused by those who lived before the Silo.
- **Ages 11-14 (Assessment):** Children are tested weekly on their aptitudes.
  - *Visual-Spatial:* Candidates for Mechanical/Mining.
  - *Linguistic/Logic:* Candidates for IT/Judicial/Supply.
  - *Interpersonal:* Candidates for Nursing/Mayor's Office/Porters.
- **The Shadow Day:** On their 14th birthday, the child is matched with an adult "Shadow". They leave their family apartment and move into the apprentice dorms or the Shadow's apartment.

1.3.3 Marriage and the Space Crisis

- **Vertical Mobility:** Marriage is the only way many citizens can move to a better level.

An ambitious Mechanical worker might marry an IT clerk to move from Level 130 to Level 30.

- **The Permit:** Judicial must approve all marriages. They check for genetic compatibility (to prevent inbreeding) and political stability.
- **The Partition Life:** Most families live in "Tiers". A 20-square-meter apartment might house a married couple and their Shadow. Privacy is a luxury afforded only to the Up Top.

1.3.4 Death: The Final Harvest

- **The Composting Protocol:** Death is not a time for grief; it is a time for reclamation.
- **The Stripping:** In the morgue (Level 31), the body is stripped. The "Death Tax" is the seizure of all the deceased's physical chits and property by the state.
- **The Soil Duty:** The remains are chemically dissolved and added to the nutrient vats on Level 72. Citizens take pride in this. A common blessing is: "May your soil be rich and your harvest be full."

Chapter 2: The Law & the Panopticon

In the Silo, "justice" is a secondary concern to "order". The legal system is designed to identify and remove biological and social friction. To the Game Master, Chapter 2 outlines the mechanics of fear, the rigid hierarchy of enforcement, and the specific ways Judicial maintains a state of perpetual, low-level paranoia.

2.1 The Two Faces of Order

The Silo's enforcement is split between the civilian-facing Sheriff and the shadow-facing Judicial. They are often at odds, representing a fundamental tension between peacekeeping and social engineering.

2.1.1 The Sheriff (The Peacekeeper) The Sheriff's Office is an ancient institution, established by the Founders to handle interpersonal conflict. * **The Mandate:** Investigating theft, assault, domestic disturbances, and "public nuisance". The Sheriff is tasked with keeping the citizens from killing each other. * **The Election:** Every 4 years, the Sheriff is elected by a popular vote. This makes the Sheriff beholden to public opinion, unlike any other department. * **The Deputies:** A small, professional force. They are the only citizens authorised to use physical force, yet they are strictly forbidden from carrying firearms. Their

primary tools are: * *The Baton:* A heavy, vulcanised rubber club. * *The Bind:* High-tensile plastic zip-ties for restraint. * *The "Mace":* A concentrated capsaicin spray derived from hot peppers grown on Level 71. * **The Star:** The Sheriff and Deputies wear a polished tin star. In the Down Deep, this star is often spat upon; Up Top, it is a sign of stability.

2.1.2 Judicial (The Warden) Judicial is not elected. They are an opaque, self-perpetuating bureaucracy that answers to no one—not even the Mayor. * **The Mandate:** Protecting the Silo from internal subversion. They interpret The Pact. Their true goal is the suppression of information and the enforcement of the status quo. * **The Clerks:** Judicial "Clerks" are more than administrators; they are inquisitors. They spend decades studying the millions of words in The Pact to find precedents for any action they wish to take. * **The Secret Police (Friends of the Silo):** Judicial does not have a uniformed military. Instead, they command a shadow network of informants. * *Recruitment:* Judicial "recruits" by catching citizens in minor infractions and offering them immunity in exchange for names. * *Operation:* They report on "Shadow Talk", relic possession, and signs of "The Syndrome".

2.2 The Justice Process

The Silo does not recognise the concept of a "fair trial". There are no defence attorneys, no juries, and no appeals.

2.2.1 The Arrest and the Holding Cells Most arrests happen in the middle of the night. * **The Level 1 Cells:** These are the primary holding cells. They are small, cold, and composed of reinforced glass facing the Viewport. * **The "Silent Sentence":** Prisoners are often held for weeks without being told their crime. They are forced to watch the dead world outside 24/7. This is designed to break their will before the hearing ever begins.

2.2.2 The Hearing A Hearing is a ritual of confirmation, not an inquiry. * **The Judge:** Usually a senior Judicial clerk. They sit behind a raised concrete dais. * **The Evidence:** Usually consists of a written report from a "Friend of the Silo" or a blurred image from a hidden camera. The accused is rarely allowed to speak for more than a few minutes. * **The Verdict:** Delivered immediately.

2.2.3 Sentences: The Three Paths

1. **The Fines:** For petty theft or laziness. The prisoner's ledger is wiped of all chits, and their rations are halved for 3 months.

2. **The Mines (Iron/Copper):** For assault, repeated theft, or moderate sedition. The prisoner is transferred to Levels 120-130. They live in cages, work 16-hour shifts, and rarely survive more than 3 years.
3. **The Cleaning:** For "desire to leave" or relic possession. This is the ultimate sentence.

2.3 Surveillance: The All-Seeing Eye

The Silo is a Panopticon—a structure designed so that the inhabitants never know when they are being watched.

2.3.1 The Camera Grid

- **Visible Cameras:** Located at stair landings and cafeteria entrances. They are bulky, slow-moving, and often used as "decoys". Citizens know where they are and avoid them.
- **Hidden "Pinhole" Cameras:** Maintained by IT but accessed by Judicial. These are hidden in light fixtures, air vents, and even inside certain pieces of machinery.
- **Technical Degradation:** Many cameras are 200 years old. The images are grainy, black-and-white, and often fail. This creates "Blind Spots"—the only places where real rebellion can be planned.

2.3.2 Game Mechanics: The Panopticon Roll When a player performs a clandestine or illegal action, the GM should determine the **Security Rating (SR)** of the area: * **Up Top (SR 1-10):** Highly monitored. Cameras are functional; informants are everywhere. * **The Mids (SR 11-40):** Moderate monitoring. Cameras are often broken; informants are busy with their own survival. * **Down Deep (SR 41-100):** Low monitoring. Judicial relies almost entirely on human informants here. * **The Roll:** The GM rolls a d100. If the roll is *lower* than the SR, the characters are not detected by technical means. If it is *higher*, they have been recorded or spotted.

2.4 Taboos and Capital Offenses

The Silo's stability depends on a controlled narrative. Anything that challenges that narrative is a capital offence.

2.4.1 The Cult of the Before (Relics) Owning a "Relic" is the fastest way to The Cleaning. * **Why?** A relic is a tangible link to a world that the Founders say never existed—

a world of abundance, colour, and freedom. * **Types of Relics:** * *Tier 1 (Curiosities):* A plastic pen, a shiny coin, a scrap of synthetic lace. (Sentence: 5 years in the Mines). * *Tier 2 (Narratives):* A photograph, a child's toy, a magazine. (Sentence: The Cleaning). * *Tier 3 (Technological):* A hard drive, a functioning battery, a digital watch. (Sentence: Immediate Cleaning and a "culling" of the possessor's family).

2.4.2 Sedition and "The Desired Word" The most dangerous thing in the Silo is a thought that travels. * **"I want to go outside":** These are the five words that end a life. Under The Pact, once these words are spoken and witnessed, they cannot be retracted. Even the Mayor cannot pardon you. * **The Mechanism:** The words are seen as a biological contagion. The person who says them is "infected" with a desire that could spread and cause a Silo-wide uprising. Execution (Cleaning) is the only "cure".

Chapter 3: The Departments (the Five Pillars)

The Silo is not a monolith; it is an uneasy alliance of five major bureaucratic and industrial powers. Each department is a silo within the Silo—possessing its own culture, its own secrets, and its own unique leverage over the others. A citizen's primary identity is not "Silo resident", but "Mechanic", "Supply Clerk", or "IT Tech".

3.1 IT (Information Technology): The Wardens of Knowledge

IT is the most powerful and the most hated department. They are located on Levels 33 and 34, a physical and social barrier between the Up Top and the Mids.

3.1.1 The Cultural Aesthetic IT levels are unnervingly quiet. While the rest of the Silo is a cacophony of voices and machinery, IT is the domain of low-frequency humming and clicking keyboards. * **The Climate:** Because the server mainframes generate immense heat but require cool air to function, IT levels are kept at a constant 15°C (60°F). IT workers are identifiable by their pale skin and their heavy, multi-layered "Vests"—knitted garments worn over their blue uniforms. * **The Temperament:** IT techs are groomed for detachment. They are taught that they are the keepers of "The Order". They view the other departments as "The Friction"—necessary but chaotic elements that must be managed.

3.1.2 Internal Hierarchy

- **The Head of IT:** Frequently the most powerful person in the Silo, even more so than the Mayor. They control the servers that run the Lottery, the digital ledgers, and the internal comms.

- **The "Shadow":** The designated successor. Unlike other shadowing apprenticeships, the IT Shadow is a secret position. Only the Head of IT knows who their successor is until the moment of transition.
- **The Hardware Techs:** The lowest rank. They crawl through the cold ducts to replace cabling and swap out failing components.

3.1.3 Departmental Leverage: The Ledger IT's power is absolute because they control the **Digital Ledger**. They can "accidentally" delete a citizen's chits, alter their work record, or place them at the top of the Lottery list. Every other department, including Judicial, is ultimately dependent on IT's hardware to function.

3.2 Mechanical: The Engine of Survival

Mechanical is the soul of the Down Deep. Based primarily on Level 144, they are the gritty, oil-stained antithesis to IT.

3.2.1 The Brotherhood of Oil Mechanical operates less like a department and more like a massive, extended family. * **The Culture:** They value physical strength, technical ingenuity, and fierce loyalty. They have their own code of honour: "The Steam Must Flow." They are the only department that routinely ignores Judicial's minor mandates, knowing that Judicial is too afraid to come down to Level 144 to enforce them. * **The Language:** They speak the thickest "Deep Talk". It is a language of short, punchy commands and technical jargon that outsiders find impenetrable.

3.2.2 The Great Generator (The Heart) Level 144 is a cathedral of steel. The Generator is a massive steam turbine, three stories tall, that converts geothermal heat into the Silo's lifeblood. * **The Vigil:** Mechanics work in "Vigils"—rotating 12-hour shifts where they monitor every valve and gauge. A "hickup" in the generator can be felt as a tremor throughout the entire Silo. * **The Blackout Protocol:** Occasionally, the Generator must be shut down for maintenance. This is a time of immense political tension. Mechanical uses the timing of these blackouts to extract concessions from the Mayor and IT.

3.2.3 Departmental Leverage: The Power Mechanical's leverage is simple: they can turn off the world. If Mechanical goes on strike, the air scrubbers stop, the water pumps fail, and the lights go out. They are the only department capable of holding the entire Silo hostage.

3.3 Supply: The Gatekeepers of Scarcity

Supply is the most visible department, located throughout the Mids and Up Top. They are the masters of the Silo's physical inventory.

3.3.1 The Bureaucracy of the Bin If you need a new lightbulb, a pair of boots, or a welding rod, you must deal with Supply. * **The Inventory:** Everything in the Silo is barcoded and tracked. Supply knows exactly how many screws are left on Level 112. They are obsessive about "The Burn Rate"—the speed at which the Silo consumes its non-renewable resources. * **The Requisition:** To get anything from Supply requires a Requisition Form, signed by a supervisor. Supply clerks take a sadistic pleasure in finding errors in these forms to deny requests.

3.3.2 Corruption and the Black Market Because they control the physical goods, Supply is the most corrupt department. * **The "Leak":** Supply clerks often "lose" items from the inventory, which then reappear on the black market for ten times their chit value. * **The Syndicates:** High-ranking Supply officers often run organised crime rings, trading essential goods for sexual favours, political secrets, or high-value relics.

3.3.3 Departmental Leverage: The Inventory Supply can starve a department of resources. They can "delay" a shipment of essential lubricants to Mechanical or "misplace" the antibiotics destined for Medical. They are the friction in every other department's gears.

3.4 Medical: The Triage Wardens

Medical is a department defined by the constant, agonising reality of limited resources. They are centred on Levels 30-32.

3.4.1 The Ethics of Scarcity Every doctor and nurse in the Silo is a master of triage. They are taught from day one: "You cannot save everyone." * **The Pharmaceutical Vault:** The most guarded place in the Silo after the IT server rooms. They possess the last remaining stocks of pre-Silo antibiotics and anaesthetics. These are used only for "High-Value Citizens" or in extreme emergencies. * **The Syndrome:** Medical is the primary investigator of "The Syndrome". They treat it not as a political crime, but as a neurological failure. They are the ones who prescribe the "docility drugs" often added to a dissident's rations.

3.4.2 Population Control (The Implant) Medical's most important task is the management of the birth control implants. * **The Surgery:** It is a routine, five-minute procedure, but it is the ultimate symbol of the Silo's control over its citizens' bodies. * **The Mystery:** Occasionally, an implant fails "naturally". Medical must determine if it was a technical failure or an illegal tampering.

3.4.3 Departmental Leverage: Health Records Everyone visits Medical. Everyone has secrets—unregistered illnesses, signs of addiction, or physical evidence of a fight. Medical's leverage is their database of every citizen's physical and mental vulnerabilities.

3.5 Hydroponics: The Breath and the Bread

Hydroponics is the humid, sweltering engine of the Mids (Levels 60-80). They are the most physically isolated department, living and working among their crops.

3.5.1 The Green Lungs Hydroponics does more than grow food; they manage the Silo's oxygen/CO2 balance. * **The Algae Vats:** Great glass cylinders filled with bubbling green liquid. This algae produces 60% of the Silo's breathable oxygen. * **The Soil-Kings:** Hydroponics workers treat their compost vats as holy ground. They are the ones who receive the "Soil Duty" (the bodies of the dead). They take the dead and turn them back into life.

3.5.2 The Culture of the Mids They are seen as simple "Dirt Farmers" by the Up Top, but they are incredibly savvy. They are the only department that understands the delicate biological balance of the Silo. * **The Rivalry with Supply:** Hydroponics hates Supply for taking the majority of their yields while providing the lowest-quality seeds and fertilisers.

3.5.3 Departmental Leverage: Famine Hydroponics can trigger a famine with a single "fungal outbreak". They can also manipulate the oxygen levels in specific sectors, inducing lethargy or euphoria to suit their political needs.

Chapter 4: The 144 Levels (the Gazetteer)

To the citizens, the Silo is a vertical continent. A person born on Level 130 might never see Level 20 in their entire life. Each "block" of levels has its own distinct micro-culture, hazards, and architecture. This Gazetteer provides the Game Master with a granular map of the world.

4.1 The Up Top (Levels 1 - 48)

Acoustics: Low, humming silence. Lighting: Bright, sterile white. Smell: Floor wax and cold air.

- **Level 1: The Threshold.**
  - *The Cafeteria:* A massive, semicircular room containing the Viewport—a 10-meter screen showing the dead hills outside. It is the only place in the Silo with a view of "distance".
  - *The Sheriff's Station:* High-security, containing the armorary (batons/pepper spray) and the primary holding cells.
  - *The Airlock:* A massive, three-stage circular vault door. It has not been opened in 20 years.
- **Levels 2-10: The Judicial Labyrinth.**
  - Hundreds of small, wood-panelled offices where clerks study The Pact. The air is dry and smells of old paper.
  - *The Mayor's Residence (Level 5):* A luxurious four-room suite with actual wooden furniture and a private bathroom.
- **Levels 30-32: The Hospital & Morgue.**
  - Equipped with pre-Silo medical tech. The "Deep Ward" (Level 32) is where the terminally ill or the politically "broken" are kept.
- **Level 34: The IT Gate.**
  - A massive steel bulkhead blocks the stairs. One must be scanned and authorised by IT security to pass. The air temp drops 10 degrees here.

4.2 The Mids (Levels 49 - 96)

Acoustics: Constant chatter and footsteps. Lighting: Warm yellow. Smell: Loam, fertiliser, and cooking soy.

- **Levels 49-55: The Great Bazaars.**
  - The landings here are widened illegally by the residents. Thousands of people gather here daily to trade physical chits for black-market goods. It is the most vibrant and chaotic place in the Silo.
- **Levels 60-80: The Hydroponic Rings.**
  - *Level 60 (The Orchard):* Contains the rare, stunted fruit trees. Heavily guarded.
  - *Level 72 (The Soil Vats):* The location of "Soil Duty". A humid, silent floor where the dead are processed.
- **Level 84: Water Reclamation.**

  - Home to the "Sand Beds"—massive, multi-story filters. The sound of rushing water is deafening.
- **Levels 90-96: The Textile Sweatshops.**
  - Loom-rooms that run 24/7. The air is thick with cotton lint. Most children shadowed to "Supply" begin their careers here.

4.3 The Down Deep (Levels 97 - 144)

Acoustics: Deafening industrial roar. Lighting: Dim red or flickering orange. Smell: Oil, coal smoke, and hot metal.

- **Levels 100-110: The Steel Slums.**
  - Housing for the heavy labourers. Living conditions are brutal. "The Grates" (Level 105) is a famous gambling den where workers bet their week's chits on rat-fights.
- **Levels 120-130: The Mines.**
  - Lateral shafts dug 500 meters into the surrounding rock.
  - *The Iron Shaft (Level 122):* The primary source of metal.
  - *The Copper Vein (Level 128):* Deep, hot, and dangerous.
- **Level 140: The Oil Reservoir.**
  - A massive, open pool of crude oil extracted from a deep-earth pocket. The fumes are toxic; workers must wear masks.
- **Level 144: The Floor of the World.**
  - *The Generator:* A titanic steam turbine.
  - *The Steam Pipes:* A forest of hissing, high-pressure pipes. A single leak here can cook a human alive in seconds.

Chapter 5: Culture, Rituals, and Sub-Factions

To understand the Silo, you must understand the "Invisible World"—the traditions and secrets that bind the 10,000 together or tear them apart.

5.1 The Dialects of Depth

- **The Up Top "High Speak":** Precise, slow, and overly formal. They use complex grammar to show status. They say "It is necessary to maintain the air scrubbers."
- **The Mids "Chit-Talk":** Fast, slang-heavy, and focused on barter. They say "Need a new filter? What's your chit count?"

- **The Down Deep "Deep Talk":** Grunted, truncated, and shouted. They speak in "Vibrations". They say "Scrubber. Bad. Fix. Now."

5.2 Cultural Rituals

5.2.1 The "Cleaning" Holiday When a Cleaning is announced, the Silo stops. It is a day of terrifying celebration. * **The Viewing:** Cafeterias are packed. People climb on tables to see the Viewport. * **The Cheer:** When the lens is wiped, the crowd erupts. It is a release of tension. For a few seconds, they see a "beautiful" world (though they don't know it's a projection). * **The Silence:** When the Cleaner falls and dies, the Silo goes into a 24-hour period of "Pact Silence". No one is supposed to speak above a whisper.

5.2.2 The "Naming" Day Because names are reused (to save space in the digital ledgers), children are not "named" at birth. They are given a number. On their 5th birthday, if they have survived, they are "Gifted" the name of a deceased ancestor in a communal ceremony.

5.3 Illegal Sub-Factions

- **The Flame Watchers:** A cult that believes fire is a purifying force. They hoard matches and lighters (strictly illegal due to oxygen consumption). They believe the Silo is a "tomb" and that fire will "wake the world".
- **The Scrap Syndicates:** The mafia of the Mids. They hijack Supply shipments and run illegal gambling rings. Their leader, "Auntie Cinder", is said to have more chits than the Mayor.
- **The Shadow Doctors:** Desperate medics who have stolen enough supplies to set up clandestine clinics. They perform the "Illegal Cut"—removing birth control implants for couples who lost the Lottery.

Chapter 6: The Engineering of Survival (Technical Specifications)

To the average citizen, the Silo's systems are magic. To the GM, they are the levers of tension. When a system fails, the stakes are immediate and life-threatening.

6.1 The Great Lungs (Air Scrubbers)

The Silo is a sealed environment. Without active filtration, the CO2 produced by 10,000 breathing humans and industrial smelting would reach lethal levels in less than six hours.

6.1.1 Mechanics of the Scrubber Located on Levels 20, 50, 80, 110, and 140, these are massive, room-sized machines. * **The Intake:** They pull air from the central stairwell shaft. * **The Chemical Bed:** Air is forced through vats of liquid amine and beds of activated charcoal. This process "scrubs" the carbon dioxide and filters out industrial toxins. * **The Output:** Clean, slightly oxygen-enriched air is pumped into the "Inner Ring" conduits and distributed to the apartments.

6.1.2 Signs of Failure

- **Stage 1 (The Headache):** PR 10. Citizens become irritable and sluggish.
- **Stage 2 (The Panic):** PR 25. Vision blurs. The air feels "thick" and "tastes like pennies".
- **Stage 3 (Hypoxia):** PR 50. Unconsciousness occurs. Death follows within 20 minutes.
- *GM Tip:* Use an air scrubber failure to force players to climb. If the Level 110 scrubber fails, the players must climb to Level 80 to find breathable air, fighting through the panicked crowds on the stairs.

6.2 The Water Cycle (Reclamation & Distribution)

Water is the Silo's most precious renewable resource. Every drop is tracked.

6.2.1 The Collection Water is collected from three sources: 1. **Atmospheric Condensate:** Moisture pulled from the air by the scrubbers. 2. **Grey/Black Water:** Recycled waste from sinks, showers, and toilets. 3. **The Deep Wells:** A slow, brackish seepage pulled from the surrounding bedrock on Level 144.

6.2.2 The Purification (Level 84) The "Sand Beds" are multi-story filters filled with progressively finer layers of sand, gravel, and charcoal. * **The Bio-Filter:** A layer of specialised bacteria that eats organic contaminants. * **The Iodine Drip:** The final stage before the water is pumped into the reservoir. This is why all Silo water has a distinct, medicinal aftertaste.

6.3 The Power Grid (Thermal Geothermal)

The Generator (Level 144) is the only source of electricity. * **The Steam Loop:** Water is pumped down into the geothermal hot-spot beneath the Silo. It returns as high-pressure steam that spins the turbine. * **The Batteries:** There are no large-scale batteries in the Silo. Electricity must be consumed as it is produced. This is why "Surplus Power" is never wasted; IT uses it to run complex background calculations, and Mechanical uses it for heavy

smelting. * **Load Shedding:** If the Generator is struggling, the Mayor orders "Load Shedding". Power is cut to non-essential levels (usually the Slums or the Mids) to keep IT and Medical functioning. This is a primary source of civil unrest.

Chapter 7: Medical Realities and "The Syndrome"

Medicine in the Silo is a blend of high-tech remnants and desperate herbalism.

7.1 The Triage Protocol

Doctors are trained in "The Math of Mercy". * **Productivity Rating:** A citizen's priority for surgery or rare medicine is tied to their work record. A "Friend of the Silo" or a senior Mechanic is always treated before a "unshadowed" labourer or a retiree. * **The Pharmaceuticals:** Antibiotics are the "Golden Chits". They are locked in a vault requiring two keys (one held by the Chief Medical Officer, one by Judicial). They are only used for infections that threaten to become Silo-wide epidemics.

7.2 The Syndrome (The Madness of Walls)

"The Syndrome" is the colloquial term for the psychological breakdown caused by the absolute confinement of the Silo. It is the Silo's equivalent of rabies—it is feared, misunderstood, and suppressed.

7.2.1 Symptoms

- **Stage 1:** Involuntary twitching of the hands. An obsession with the Viewport.
- **Stage 2:** "The Whispers". The patient begins to hear the wind or see "the green" in their dreams.
- **Stage 3:** The Breakdown. The patient begins to run or climb frantically, screaming that they "need to breathe".
- *The Treatment:* In the early stages, "Docility Drugs" (lithium and sedatives) are added to the patient's water. In the late stages, the patient is arrested by the Sheriff and usually sent to The Cleaning.

Chapter 8: The Shadow Economy and Barter Tables

While "Chits" are the official currency, the real business of the Silo happens in the shadows.

8.1 The Value of "Nothing"

Items that an adventurer in another game would ignore are priceless in the Silo. * **A Clean Rag:** Used for filtration or hygiene. (Barter: 2 meals). * **A Handful of Salt:** Harvested from the water reclamation filters. (Barter: A pair of used boots). * **A Sewing Needle:** Hand-filed from a scrap of wire. (Barter: 10 Chits). * **Real Sugar:** Stolen from the Mayor's kitchen. (Barter: A favour from a Porter).

8.2 Barter Exchange Table (GM Guide)

Item	Chit Value	Barter Equivalent
Pouch of Chicory (Coffee)	20 Chits	2 hours of labour
Bottle of "Potato Gin"	50 Chits	A minor secret about a neighbour
Functional Flashlight	200 Chits	A week's rations
Pre-Silo Tool (Relic)	1000+ Chits	Immediate arrest or a life-debt
Extra Water (1 Gallon)	5 Chits	A favour on the stairs

Chapter 9: The Daily Simulation (Routines and Calendars)

To make the Silo feel "alive", the GM must manage the passage of time. Life in the Silo is rhythmic, punctuated by the mechanical cycles of the structure.

9.1 The "Clock" of the Silo

There is no sun to mark the day. Time is defined by the **Illumination Cycle**. * **06:00 (The Dawn Glow):** The main halogen lights in the hallways and stairwells flicker from dim red to warm yellow. This is "Morning". * **06:00 - 08:00 (The Rush):** The stairs are at their most congested. 10,000 people are moving to their workplaces. Porters are running "Express Routes". * **12:00 (Mid-Cycle):** The lights pulse three times. This is the official lunch hour. Cafeterias on every level are at maximum capacity. * **18:00 - 20:00 (The Return):** The evening rush back to the residential rings. * **22:00 (The Dimming):** The main lights fade to a low, orange "Night Light". Level curfew is not officially enforced except Up Top, but being on the stairs at night is considered suspicious and will draw the attention of the Sheriff's night deputies.

9.2 The Calendar of the Dead

The Silo doesn't use months like "January". They use "Cycle Months" based on the age of the Silo. * **Year 242, Month 4:** This marks the time since the "Founding". * **Commemoration Days:** * *Founders' Week:* A seven-day period of extra labour to "honour" the builders. Rations are often increased by 5% to prevent riots. * *The Day of the Viewport:* A day where the Mayor gives a speech about the "Horror of the Outside". * *Legacy Day:* A holiday where citizens are encouraged to visit their ancestors' names in the digital archives.

Chapter 10: NPCs and the Human Element

The Silo is a pressure cooker. These NPCs are archetypes the GM can use to populate any level.

10.1 The Up Top Bureaucrats

- **Clerk Halloway (Judicial):** A man who has memorised every word of The Pact. He is not evil, but he is a literalist. He believes a single loose screw in a stair-tread is a sign of moral decay.
- **Deputy Miller (Sheriff):** A woman who grew up in the Down Deep but was shadowed to the Sheriff. She is torn between her loyalty to her family in the grease and her duty to the Up Top.

10.2 The Mids Workers

- **Auntie Cinder (Scrap Syndicate):** She lives in a room filled with "Legal Scrap" that looks suspiciously like relics. She knows the location of every hidden camera on Levels 50 through 60.
- **Farmer Jole (Hydroponics):** A man who talks to his algae vats. He believes the plants can sense the "mood" of the Silo. He is the first to know when a rebellion is brewing.

10.3 The Down Deep Outcasts

- **"Oil-Skin" Pete:** A man who survived a steam-pipe explosion on Level 144. He is scarred and barely speaks, but he can hear a failing bearing in a motor from three floors away.
- **The Rat-King:** A teenager who lives in the air-ducts. He knows the secret routes between levels that aren't on the blueprints. He trades information for sugar-chits.

Chapter 11: Geography Deep Dive (the Forgotten Spaces)

Not all of the Silo is occupied. There are "Dead Spaces" that offer opportunities for exploration and danger.

11.1 The Mechanical Crawls

Between the "Outer Ring" (living space) and the "Inner Ring" (conduits) lies a 1-meter wide vertical gap. * **The Ladder-Rungs:** A series of rusted metal rungs allow vertical movement without using the stairs. * **The Hazard:** These shafts are used for waste-pipe maintenance. They are dark, slippery, and infested with the Silo's hardy, oversized rats.

11.2 The "Ghost" Levels

Every few decades, a level is abandoned due to structural failure, toxic leak, or "political quarantine". * **Level 40 (The Sealed Library):** Rumoured to contain physical books from the Before. The airlocks are welded shut. Judicial guards this level 24/7. * **Level 101 (The Flooded Tier):** A water main burst fifty years ago, and the level was never fully drained. It is a swampy, dark ruin used as a hideout for "The Syndicates".

Chapter 12: The Syndrome and the Psychology of Walls

To truly GM the Silo, you must understand the "Agoraphobia of the Soul".

12.1 The Terror of the Open

Citizens are not just trapped; they are *afraid* of the idea of not being trapped. * **The Reaction:** If a player were to suddenly show a citizen a picture of a wide-open field, the citizen wouldn't feel joy; they would feel a physical sensation of vertigo and nausea. * **The Projection:** This is why the "projection" in the Cleaning suits is so effective. It is so beautiful that it causes a sensory overload, making the Cleaner desperate to "show" the others what they are seeing.

12.2 The "Shadow Talk"

In the cafeterias, people speak in code. * "The air is thin today" = Judicial is watching. * "The steam is high" = Mechanical is planning a strike. * "The Viewport is clear" = Someone

is planning to say “The Words”.

Chapter 13: The Complete Level Gazetteer (1 - 144)

The following is a definitive, level-by-level accounting of the Silo’s distribution. The GM can use this list to determine exactly what a character encounters when stepping off the stairs at any given depth.

The Up Top (Levels 1 - 48)

- **Level 1:** The Air-Lock, The Viewport, Cafeteria, Sheriff’s Station, Holding Cells.
- **Levels 2 - 3:** Judicial Administration (The “Inner Circle” offices).
- **Levels 4 - 6:** Senior Residential (Mayor, Head of IT, Head of Judicial).
- **Levels 7 - 12:** The Pact Libraries (Historical Law & Clerical Offices).
- **Level 13:** The Communication Hub (Pneumatic tube central exchange).
- **Levels 14 - 18:** Elite Education (The “Founders’ Schools” for Up Top youth).
- **Levels 19 - 25:** Upper-Tier Apartments (Clerks, Senior IT Techs, Senior Deputies).
- **Levels 26 - 29:** IT Support Staff Residential.
- **Level 30:** Medical (Emergency & Surgery).
- **Level 31:** Medical (Long-term Care & Quarantine).
- **Level 32:** The Morgue & Pre-Compost Preparation.
- **Level 33:** IT Secure Server Rooms (Alpha).
- **Level 34:** IT Secure Server Rooms (Beta) & The Gate.
- **Levels 35 - 40:** High-End Supply Depots (Precision tools, electronics).
- **Levels 41 - 44:** White-Collar Residential (Supply Officers, Junior Clerks).
- **Levels 45 - 48:** Primary Air Scrubbers (Up Top Block).

The Mids (Levels 49 - 96)

- **Level 49:** The Great Exchange (The Silo’s largest Bazaar).
- **Levels 50 - 55:** Mid-Tier Residential (The “Merchant Levels”).
- **Levels 56 - 59:** Light Industry (Lightbulb manufacture, tool repair).
- **Levels 60 - 64:** The Orchards (Stunted fruit trees, berry bushes).
- **Levels 65 - 70:** The Grain Tiers (Corn, soy, wheat).
- **Level 71:** The Spice & Medicine Gardens (Peppers, herbs, medicinal plants).
- **Level 72:** The Compost Vats (Soil Duty Floor).
- **Levels 73 - 78:** The Green Vats (Algae production & Oxygenation).

- **Levels 79 - 83:** Agricultural Worker Residential.
- **Level 84:** Water Reclamation (The Sand Beds).
- **Level 85:** Water Storage (Primary Mids Reservoir).
- **Level 86:** Air Scrubber (Mids Block).
- **Levels 87 - 92:** The Textile Tiers (Cotton looms & Synthetic spinning).
- **Levels 93 - 96:** The Repair Wards (Recycling broken goods from Up Top).

The Down Deep (Levels 97 - 144)

- **Levels 97 - 105:** Labourer Slums (High density, high noise).
- **Levels 106 - 110:** The Industrial Foundries (Steel smelting & Smelting).
- **Level 111:** Air Scrubber (Upper Down Deep Block).
- **Levels 112 - 118:** Heavy Manufacturing (Pipes, beams, turbine blades).
- **Levels 119 - 120:** Tool & Die Shops (The "Masters of the Grease").
- **Level 121:** Mining Administration & Prisoner Processing.
- **Levels 122 - 125:** The Iron Mines (Lateral shafts).
- **Levels 126 - 128:** The Copper & Coal Mines (Lateral shafts).
- **Level 129:** The Waste Vats (Industrial byproduct disposal).
- **Level 130:** Mining Worker Residential (The "Dusty Levels").
- **Levels 131 - 135:** Oil Pumping & Refining (Lube oils & Petroleum).
- **Levels 136 - 140:** Fuel & Oil Storage Tanks.
- **Level 141:** Air Scrubber (Deep Block).
- **Level 142:** Mechanical Residential (Upper Tier).
- **Level 143:** Mechanical Residential (Lower Tier) & The Armoury.
- **Level 144:** The Generator, Geothermal Intake, & Deep Well.

Chapter 14: The Mechanical Physics of the Silo

To run a realistic Silo game, the GM must account for the physical constraints of the structure.

14.1 Atmospheric Pressure and Temperature

- **Pressure:** The air is slightly more pressurised in the Down Deep. Characters ascending too quickly (e.g., a Porter running 100 levels in an hour) may experience "The Squeeze"—mild vertigo and ear pain.
- **Temperature Gradient:**
  - *Up Top:* 20°C (68°F) - Climate controlled.

- *IT Levels:* 15°C (60°F) - Chilled for servers.
- *The Mids:* 25°C (77°F) - Humid for crops.
- *The Down Deep:* 35°C (95°F) - Heated by the Generator and rock pressure.

14.2 The Logistics of Message Tubes

The Silo uses a pneumatic tube system for official messages. * **The Hub (Level 13):** Every message goes here first. * **The Speed:** A tube takes roughly 5 minutes to travel from Level 1 to Level 144. * **The Sabotage:** Cutting a pneumatic tube is a capital crime. It halts communication for an entire block.

Chapter 15: Character Progression and the "Tiers"

As characters gain experience, they do not just "level up"; they gain **Silo Standing**.

15.1 Standing Ranks

- **Rank 0 (The Drudge):** You have no reputation. Supply treats you with contempt.
- **Rank 1 (The Reliable):** You have a clean work record. You can trade favours with your local shadow.
- **Rank 2 (The Key-Holder):** You are a supervisor or senior artisan. You have keys to certain maintenance hatches.
- **Rank 3 (The Essential):** You are known to the Mayor or a Department Head. You are too important to be easily "disappeared" by Judicial.

Chapter 16: Crime, Punishment, and the Black Market (Extended)

In a world of total scarcity, every object has a story, and every crime is an act of desperation or rebellion.

16.1 The Hierarchy of Contraband

The GM should classify illegal items to determine the risk of discovery.

- **Class C (Nuisance):** Extra sugar rations, home-brewed "potato gin", unapproved clothing dyes, gambling chits.
  - *Penalty:* Loss of 1 month's wages and "The Shaming" (cleaning the cafeteria floors for a week).

- **Class B (Theft/Sabotage):** Stolen medical supplies (non-narcotic), unauthorised tools, bypass-keys for maintenance hatches, "Deep Talk" dictionaries.
  - *Penalty:* 2-5 years in the Mines.
- **Class A (Treason):** Relics (pre-Silo artefacts), maps of the "Before", radio transmitters, firearms, and birth-control tampering kits.
  - *Penalty:* The Cleaning.

16.2 The Anatomy of a Black Market Deal

Transactions in the Mids don't happen in the open. * **The "Handshake":** A specialised sequence of hand signals used to identify a buyer or seller. * **The Dead Drop:** Money (chits or scrap) is left in a specific stair-railing notch; the goods are left in a different location (usually an air duct or a laundry bin) an hour later. * **The "Wash":** To use stolen chits, they must be "washed" through a Supply clerk who can alter the digital ledger to show the chits were earned through "Overtime Labour".

Chapter 17: Psychology and Social Tensions (Deep Dive)

The Silo is a pressure cooker of repressed emotions and inherited trauma.

17.1 The "Shadow" Resentment

The Shadowing process (apprenticeship) creates intense lifelong bonds and equally intense lifelong resentments. * **The Bad Match:** Not all Shadows and apprentices get along. A cruel Shadow can make an apprentice's life a living hell for six years. * **The "Untouchables":** Those whose Shadows died before the apprenticeship was completed are often viewed with superstitious dread, as if they are "cursed" by the Silo.

17.2 The "Up-Down" Conflict

The social distance between Level 1 and Level 144 is greater than the physical distance. * **Vertical Racism:** Up Top residents view those from the Down Deep as biologically inferior—"Grease-Monkeys" who are mentally slow due to the noise. * **The "Rust-Born":** Down Deep residents view Up Top elites as "Soft-Hands" who wouldn't last a day without the Generator they don't understand.

Chapter 18: The Architecture of the "Inner Ring"

While the citizens live in the "Outer Ring", the "Inner Ring" is the Silo's hidden nervous system.

18.1 The Conduits

- **The Water Main:** A massive 1-meter wide steel pipe that carries the Silo's lifeblood. It is always cold and sweating with condensation.
- **The Power Trunk:** A bundle of thousands of cables, each as thick as a human arm. They hum with a high-pitched frequency that causes headaches in anyone who lingers near the access hatches.
- **The Air Shafts:** Vertical tunnels 2 meters wide. They are the only places in the Silo with a constant, artificial wind.

18.2 The "Vents" (The Rogue Highway)

Small, secondary air vents (30cm wide) crisscross every level. * **The Rat-Runs:** Used by "The Rat-King" and other outcasts. A small character (or a trained animal) can move between rooms and levels without using the stairs. * **The Filters:** Every 5 levels, the vents are blocked by a heavy metal mesh filter. Removing these triggers an alarm in IT.

Chapter 19: Recreation and the Human Spirit

How do 10,000 people keep from going mad?

19.1 Games of Chance

- **"The Drop":** A popular game where players bet on which floor a dropped coin will land on (using the nets).
- **"Chit-Flip":** A simple, high-stakes game of bluffing and hand-counts.
- **"The Grid":** A complex board game played on a 144-square grid, representing the Silo. The goal is to "shadow" your pieces to the top without being "cleaned" by the opponent.

19.2 The Acoustic Culture

- **The "Echo-Choirs":** Groups of singers who stand on different levels of the stairs and harmonise using the shaft's natural reverb. It is the most beautiful sound in the Silo.

- **The "Wall-Drummers":** A form of protest where residents on multiple levels strike the concrete walls in a rhythmic pattern, creating a sound that the Sheriff cannot easily trace to a single source.

Chapter 20: The GM's Toolkit (Situational Tables)

The following tables are designed for quick-generation of sensory details and minor complications during play.

20.1 "What Do I Smell?" (Level Atmosphere)

Roll (d10)	Result
1	Sharp iodine and sterile floor wax (Up Top).
2	Damp earth and decaying vegetable matter (Mids).
3	Bitter crude oil and hot, oxidised iron (Down Deep).
4	Recycled sweat and unwashed cotton (The Stairs).
5	The metallic tang of ozone from a short-circuit.
6	Stale algae gruel and synthetic chicory.
7	The sweet, sickly smell of the "Potato Gin" home-brew.
8	Dust, old paper, and ancient glue (The Archives).
9	Chlorine and stagnant water (Reclamation).
10	A sudden, terrifying whiff of "Outside" (A hallucination or leak).

20.2 Stairwell Encounters

Roll (d10)	Result
1	A Porter "Chain" (6+ people) running full tilt; move or be trampled.

Roll (d10)	Result
2	A grieving family moving a body down to the Compost.
3	A pedlar selling "Fresh" Algae-Crisps (3 White Chits).
4	A Sheriff's Deputy checking IDs for a "Random Inspection".
5	A group of children playing "The Drop" with a piece of scrap.
6	A mechanic covered in black grease, arguing with a Supply clerk.
7	A "Shadow" crying because they hate their assigned mentor.
8	An old man staring at the wall, whispering "The Words".
9	A Judicial Clerk being carried in a sedan-chair (Extreme luxury).
10	A sudden, localised blackout; everyone freezes in the dark.

Chapter 21: The History of the "Ruin" (Official Version)

The following is the only history allowed to be taught in the Silo schools. Any variation from this text is sedition.

- **The Age of Hubris:** Before the Silo, humanity lived on the "Surface". They built cities that touched the clouds and flew through the air in metal birds. They forgot the earth that fed them.
- **The Great Fire:** Because of their greed, the people of the Before fought a war that set the sky on fire. The air became poison, and the soil became ash.
- **The Founders' Sacrifice:** Foreseeing the end, the Wise Founders built the 144 Levels. They gathered the last 10,000 righteous people and sealed the doors.
- **The Pact:** To ensure the Great Fire never happened again, the Founders wrote The Pact—the laws that keep us safe from our own nature.
- **The Duty:** Our only duty is to survive until the Earth is healed. To look outside is

to invite the Great Fire back into our lungs.

Chapter 22: The Shadow Pharmacy (List of Drugs)

Medical resources are rare, but chemical control is a primary tool of the state.

- **"The Blue" (Lithium/Sedative Mix):** Added to the water of "agitated" levels. It causes lethargy and emotional blunting. (Sign: A faint blue tint to the morning coffee).
- **"The Sharp" (Amphetamine Remnant):** Used by Porters and IT Techs to work 36-hour shifts. It causes paranoia and heart palpitations. (Sign: Dilated pupils and rapid "High Speak").
- **"The Blank" (The Amnesiac):** A terrifyingly powerful drug used by Judicial. It wipes the last 24-48 hours of memory. (Sign: A metallic taste in the mouth and a lost day).
- **"The Mercy" (Morphine):** The most valuable drug in the Silo. Used only for amputations or terminal cases. A single vial can buy a permanent move to the Up Top.

Chapter 23: The Mechanics of the Suit (Technical)

The Suit used in The Cleaning is a masterpiece of deceptive engineering.

- **The Inner Layer:** Comfortable cotton. It makes the condemned feel safe.
- **The Outer Layer:** A thin, synthetic polymer. It looks airtight, but it is porous to the specific nanobots of the outside.
- **The Visor:** A dual-layered glass. Between the layers is a liquid-crystal display. When the airlock opens, the display activates, showing a pre-recorded, 360-degree loop of a green, lush world.
- **The Seal (Heat-Tape):** This is the "kill switch". IT provides a specific tape that looks like industrial sealant but is designed to dissolve in exactly 180 seconds when exposed to the outside atmosphere. Once the tape fails, the toxic air breaches the suit.

Chapter 24: The Geology of the Silo

- **The Bedrock:** The Silo is encased in solid granite. This is why the "Mines" are so difficult to dig.

- **The Aquifer:** A slow-moving river of brackish water flows 50 meters beneath Level 144. This is the source of the "Deep Well" water.
- **The Geothermal Pocket:** A localised volcanic vent provides the steam for the Generator. It is the reason the Down Deep is so hot. If the vent ever shifts, the Silo loses its power forever.

Chapter 25: A Final Word on Atmosphere

To run the Silo correctly, the GM must never let the players feel "safe". * The lights should always be a little too dim. * The air should always be a little too stale. * The food should always be a little too bland. * And the neighbour should always be a little too curious.

The Silo is not just a building. It is a tomb that hasn't been closed yet.

Chapter 26: The Faces of the Silo (NPC Roster)

To run a setting driven by political tension and scarcity, the GM needs characters whose motivations intersect and conflict. Below is a roster of key NPCs across the sectors.

26.1 The Up Top (the Elite & the Enforcers)

- **Mayor Tamsin Rook (The Pragmatist):**
  - *Role:* The elected leader of the Silo, based on Level 5.
  - *Appearance:* Elderly, sharp-eyed, uses a walking cane carved from an ancient desk leg.
  - *Motivation:* Maintaining the balance between IT and Mechanical. She hates Judicial but knows she cannot openly oppose them.
  - *The Secret:* She is quietly stockpiling unrecorded antibiotics, suspecting an impending conflict.
- **Chief Deputy Harlan Fiske (The Loyal Hound):**
  - *Role:* The Sheriff's right hand. Level 1.
  - *Appearance:* Heavily scarred from a riot in the Mids twenty years ago. Always chewing on chicory root.
  - *Motivation:* Protecting the Mayor at all costs. He views the Sheriff as a politician and himself as the actual law.

  - *The Secret:* He knows his deputies are taking bribes from the Scrap Syndicates and allows it, so long as the violence stays out of the Up Top.
- **Inquisitor Sel Verin (Judicial):**
  - *Role:* Senior Judicial Clerk. Level 8.
  - *Appearance:* Immaculate white uniform. Speaks softly and never breaks eye contact.
  - *Motivation:* The absolute enforcement of The Pact. He believes the Silo is too lenient and that a "purging" is necessary.
  - *The Secret:* He possesses a Tier 2 Relic (a silver pocket watch) which he uses to hypnotise himself during stressful interrogations.
- **Merrow Hale (Head of IT):**
  - *Role:* The true power in the Silo. Level 34.
  - *Appearance:* Soft, pale, and constantly sweating despite the cold of the servers.
  - *Motivation:* Protecting "The Order". He views the citizens as livestock to be managed for the 500-year plan.
  - *The Secret:* He holds the key to the secret elevator and regularly communicates with Silo 1.

26.2 The Mids (the Hustlers & the Harvesters)

- **Quartermaster "Hooks" Sera Krail (Supply):**
  - *Role:* Runs the primary supply depot on Level 50.
  - *Appearance:* Missing two fingers on his left hand. Wears a vest with a dozen locked pockets.
  - *Motivation:* Wealth accumulation. He wants to buy his way into an Up Top retirement.
  - *The Secret:* He is the primary supplier for the Shadow Doctors, trading stolen medical gear for exorbitant chits.
- **Matron Ysra Thorn (Hydroponics):**
  - *Role:* The undisputed boss of the Algae Vats on Level 72.
  - *Appearance:* Stained green fingertips, muscular, smells strongly of fertiliser.
  - *Motivation:* Protecting her crop and her workers. She treats the vats like her children.
  - *The Secret:* She has engineered a localised strain of algae that can produce a mild hallucinogen, which she sells to the Porters.
- **Dr. Len Morra (The Shadow Doctor):**
  - *Role:* A rogue medic operating out of a vent on Level 88.

  - *Appearance:* Wears a stolen, blood-stained lab coat. Exhausted and cynical.
  - *Motivation:* Providing medical care to those who cannot risk going to the Level 30 hospital.
  - *The Secret:* He performs illegal removals of birth control implants, keeping the removed implants in a jar to prove he beat the system.
- **Tavi Rune (The Porter Union Boss):**
  - *Role:* The unofficial leader of the Porters. Based on the Level 60 landings.
  - *Appearance:* Lean, heavily tattooed with stair-level numbers. Calves like steel cables.
  - *Motivation:* Maintaining the Porters' neutrality and monopoly on transit.
  - *The Secret:* She intercepts and reads 10% of all Judicial messages before delivering them, maintaining a massive blackmail ledger.

26.3 The Down Deep (the Grease & the Grime)

- **Shift-Boss Rourke (Mechanical):**
  - *Role:* The lord of Level 144. Runs the Generator.
  - *Appearance:* Massive, completely bald, and covered in permanent engine soot. He communicates primarily in hand gestures due to deafness from the turbine.
  - *Motivation:* Keeping the Generator running. He demands utter perfection from his mechanics.
  - *The Secret:* He knows about the massive steel vault door beneath the oil reservoir (The Digger) but has kept it hidden from IT, waiting for the right moment to breach it.
- **"Auntie Cinder" (Scrap Syndicate Boss):**
  - *Role:* Organised crime leader. Level 101 (The Flooded Tier).
  - *Appearance:* Wears an absurd, patched-together coat of many colours. Sits on a chair made of welded piping.
  - *Motivation:* Control of the black market. She wants to corner the market on smuggled food from the Mids.
  - *The Secret:* She is not actually old; she is 30, but suffers from a rare aging disease that Medical refused to treat, fuelling her hatred of the Up Top.
- **Mira Quell (The Savant):**
  - *Role:* A mid-level mechanic, brilliant but insubordinate. Level 130.
  - *Appearance:* Intense, focused, always carrying a customised multi-tool.
  - *Motivation:* Figuring out how things *really* work. She does not accept "Because The Pact says so" as an answer.

- *The Secret:* She has been quietly stealing high-grade wire and heat-tape to investigate why the Cleaning suits always fail.

Chapter 27: Armory, Gear, and the Economy of Violence

Combat in the Silo is desperate, unarmored, and brutally close-quarters. There are no gunsmiths. Every weapon is a tool that has been repurposed for violence.

27.1 Weapons (the Arsenal of Scarcity)

- **The "Shiv" (Concealable Melee):**
  - *Description:* A piece of shattered view-screen glass wrapped in cloth, or a sharpened screwdriver.
  - *Mechanics/Role:* Low damage, easily concealed. Favoured by Up Top assassins and Mids pickpockets. If the glass breaks in a wound, it causes persistent bleeding.
- **The Heavy Wrench (Blunt Melee):**
  - *Description:* A 2-foot steel pipe wrench. Heavy and slow.
  - *Mechanics/Role:* High crushing damage. Can break bones and dent thin bulkheads. Favoured by Mechanics and Porters.
- **The Sheriff's Baton (Law Enforcement):**
  - *Description:* Vulcanised rubber over a steel core.
  - *Mechanics/Role:* Designed to incapacitate, not kill. Has a high chance to stun or knock a target unconscious. Strictly illegal for civilians to possess.
- **The Pneumatic Rivet Gun (Ranged Heavy):**
  - *Description:* An industrial tool used for patching the Silo walls. It must be attached to a heavy, portable compressed-air tank worn on the back.
  - *Mechanics/Role:* Fires heavy steel rivets. Incredibly deadly at close range, but wildly inaccurate past 10 meters. The air tank is explosive if punctured. Favoured by the Scrap Syndicates.
- **The "Flash-Bang" (Alchemical):**
  - *Description:* A makeshift explosive crafted by Hydroponics workers using fertiliser and spark-plugs.
  - *Mechanics/Role:* Does little physical damage but causes deafening noise and blinding light. Used to scatter crowds or escape Sheriff's deputies on the stairs.

27.2 Armor (the Myth of Protection)

True armour does not exist. Wearing heavy metal plates on the stairs would cause exhaustion in an hour. * **The "Thick-Coat":** Heavy denim or canvas patched with dozens of layers of scrap fabric. Provides minor protection against slashing (shivs). * **Boiled Rabbit Leather:** Worn exclusively by the hunters in the Mids. Tough, but smells terrible. Provides moderate protection. * **Sheriff's Riot Gear (Pre-Silo):** The only true armour. Kevlar vests and hardened plastic helmets. They are ancient, cracked, and heavily guarded in the Level 1 armoury.

27.3 Adventuring Gear (Survival in the Cylinder)

- **The Crank-Torch:** A heavy, brass flashlight powered by a hand-crank dynamo. 1 minute of cranking = 10 minutes of dim, yellow light. Essential for navigating the vents.
- **The Water-Thief:** A specialised rubber hose with a needle-valve. Used to illegally siphon water from the high-pressure mains without alerting IT sensors.
- **The "Sniffer":** A repurposed industrial sensor used by Mechanics to detect high concentrations of CO2 or methane. Vital when exploring abandoned levels.
- **Pneumatic Bypass Key:** An incredibly rare, illegal master key that can open the hatches to the pneumatic tube system, allowing a character to intercept messages.

Chapter 28: Ecology, Flora, and Silo Fauna

The Silo is a closed ecosystem. While the apex predator is humanity (and Judicial), there is a thriving, desperate ecology that exists in the margins.

28.1 Fauna (the Meat and the Vermin)

- **The "Mids Rabbit":**
  - *Description:* Genetically modified for rapid gestation and high meat yield. They are kept in massive, stacked cages on Levels 65-68.
  - *The "Barons":* The families that control the rabbit breeding hold immense soft power. They are ruthless and guard their breeding stock with violence.
  - *Escapees:* Occasionally, a rabbit escapes into the vents. Catching a "feral" rabbit is a massive windfall for a Down Deep worker.
- **The Silo Rat (The "Grease-Biter"):**

  - *Description:* Large, aggressive, and highly adaptable. They feed on compost runoff and industrial lubricants.
  - *Hazard:* They are known to chew through essential wiring and will attack humans if cornered in the vents. Some Down Deep slums actively hunt them for meat (colloquially called "Shadow-Rabbit").
- **The Moths (The Cotton Blight):**
  - *Description:* Pale, blind moths that infest the textile levels.
  - *Hazard:* They eat hydroponic cotton. A moth infestation can destroy the Silo's clothing supply. When an outbreak occurs, Judicial authorises "The Burn"—flooding an entire level with toxic smoke to kill the larvae.

28.2 Flora (the Hydroponic Balance)

- **The "Green Lung" Algae:**
  - *Description:* The primary oxygen producer. It is thick, viscous, and highly sensitive to temperature.
  - *The "Algae-Rot":* A bacterial infection that turns the algae black. When this happens, oxygen levels drop, and the algae emits a stench like rotting meat.
- **The "Iron-Weed":**
  - *Description:* A stubborn, invasive vine that grows in the condensation on the concrete walls of the Down Deep.
  - *Use:* It is inedible, but Mechanics boil it down to create a crude, sticky paste used for patching low-pressure pipe leaks.
- **The "Sleep-Root" (Illegal):**
  - *Description:* A mutated form of potato grown in secret in the lower Mids.
  - *Use:* When fermented, it produces a highly addictive, hallucinogenic liquor. The Sheriff actively hunts Sleep-Root brewers.

Chapter 29: The Rumor Mill (d20 Generator)

Porters run the stairs, and gossip is the true currency of the Silo. When players ask "What's the word?", roll a d20.

Roll	The Rumour on the Stairs	Truth Level
1	"I heard the Mayor is sick. Not 'caught a cold' sick. 'Medical doesn't know what it is' sick."	Mostly True. (She was poisoned by Judicial).
2	"Supply is holding back the new boots. They want Mechanical to fix the Level 40 scrubber first."	True. (Standard inter-departmental blackmail).
3	"A kid in the Down Deep found a door that wasn't on the blueprints. A metal door, welded shut."	True. (It leads to the Digger).
4	"The last Cleaner didn't die right away. I saw them walk over the hill."	False. (A trick of the camera lens, but it breeds hope).
5	"IT is listening through the new lightbulbs. They put microphones in the glass."	False. (Paranoia, but Judicial encourages the rumour).
6	"The water on Level 80 tastes like copper. Someone bled into the sand-beds."	True. (A murder was covered up by the Syndicates).
7	"Judicial is planning a random 'Sweep' of the Mids tonight. Hide your relics."	Mostly True. (A sweep is planned, but for the Down Deep).
8	"The Generator hummed a different tune last night. A warning alarm. We're losing power."	True. (A bearing is failing; Mechanical is panicking).
9	"A Porter found a message tube from the Before. It says there are other Silos."	False. (A forgery created by the Flame Watchers).
10	"The Shadow Doctors have a cure for The Syndrome. They just charge 100 Red Chits for it."	False. (They only have sedatives).

Roll	The Rumour on the Stairs	Truth Level
11	"I saw a rat the size of a dog pull a tool-bag into the vents on Level 110."	Mostly True. (The rats are getting bigger).
12	"The Sheriff's deputies are buying up all the pepper-spray from Hydroponics. A riot is coming."	True. (The Sheriff anticipates a strike).
13	"There's a ghost on the Level 40 landing. You can hear it crying at night."	False. (It's the wind whistling through a cracked air duct).
14	"The Lottery is rigged. IT only picks couples who are 'Friends of the Silo'."	100% True.
15	"A mechanic found a cache of old-world seeds. Real apples. He's growing them in secret."	True. (A major plot hook).
16	"The Mayor's husband didn't fall down the stairs. He was pushed by a Porter."	False. (He jumped).
17	"If you tap the water pipes three times, the Scrap Syndicates will come find you."	Mostly True. (It's a signal to buy black-market goods).
18	"The outside isn't toxic. The suits are toxic. That's what kills the Cleaners."	100% True. (The most dangerous rumour in the Silo).
19	"Supply is substituting ground rat meat for the rabbit rations. You can taste the grease."	True. (A desperate measure during a recent famine).

Roll	The Rumour on the Stairs	Truth Level
20	"I heard someone whisper 'I want to go outside' on Level 20. But Judicial didn't arrest them."	True. (The person who said it was the Head of IT, testing a new clerk).

Chapter 30: The GM's Quick-Reference Sheets

These tools are meant to sit beside the GM during play. They are not new lore; they are compressed forms of the setting so you can answer table questions fast.

30.1 Travel Time by Stair

Distance	Fit Citizen	Porter	Citizen Carrying Load / Escorting Injured
1-5 levels	10-20 minutes	5-10 minutes	20-30 minutes
6-15 levels	30-75 minutes	20-40 minutes	1-2 hours
16-30 levels	2-4 hours	1-2 hours	Half a day
31-60 levels	Most of a day	4-6 hours	A full day and likely an overnight stop
61+ levels	An expedition	A brutal all-day run	Multiple days, supplies required

- **Fast Rule:** Any non-Porter crossing more than 20 levels arrives tired, sweaty, thirsty, and socially out of place.
- **Faster Rule:** If the exact time does not matter, ask whether the trip is *local*, *serious*, or *expedition-scale* and narrate accordingly.

30.2 Security and Response at a Glance

Zone	Typical SR	First Response	Most Common Complication
Viewport / IT / Judicial corridors	1-10	IT security, Judicial clerk, or armed deputy	Someone already knows the PCs' names
Mayor / Medical / major offices	11-25	Clerk, orderly, deputy	Paper trail and witnesses
Markets / Mids residential tiers	26-45	Local deputy or neighbourhood informant	Crowds, rumours, and collateral witnesses
Hydroponics / Supply floors	30-50	Foreman, quartermaster, or hungry workers	Shortage panic spreads fast
Down Deep slums / maintenance crawls	45-75	Local toughs, Mechanics, or nobody at all	Danger comes from the environment first
Ghost levels / vents / dead spaces	70-100	No official response until after the fact	The place itself tries to kill them

30.3 Everyday Costs, Bribes, and Favors

Need	Typical Price
A hot meal with actual protein	8-15 chits or a meaningful favour
A bed for a night on a stranger's floor	5 chits, gossip, or guard duty
A stamped form moved to the top of the stack	10-30 chits
Looking the other way during a minor infraction	1 meal, 1 bottle, or 1 name
A Porter carrying a private package off-ledger	15-40 chits depending on risk
A Mechanical part "that does not officially exist"	Barter plus future leverage
Real medicine	More than most citizens can pay; almost always comes with strings

30.4 Punishments at a Glance

Offence	Usual Outcome
Queue-jumping, ration skimming, petty theft	Fines, ration cuts, public humiliation
Forgery, black-market dealing, repeat theft	Holding cells, beatings, transfer to labour
Illegal tampering with infrastructure	Mine labour, political suspicion, family blacklisting
Relic possession	Interrogation, disappearance, or being made an informant
Sedition / "I want to go outside"	Cleaning

Chapter 31: Core Play Procedure (System-Agnostic)

The Silo works best when risk feels cumulative. Use the following procedures with any base system to keep pressure rising even when the PCs technically "succeed".

31.1 When to Call for Uncertainty

Call for a roll, test, or move only when at least one of the following is true:

- The action risks official notice.
- The action risks bodily harm, exhaustion, or contamination.
- The action could cost scarce time, rations, tools, or social trust.
- Failure would make the next scene more dangerous rather than stop play.

If none apply, let the PCs do it. Life in the Silo is already hard enough.

31.2 The Three Pressure Tracks

Track these openly or privately:

Track	It Measures	Typical Triggers	At 4
Stress	Fear, crowding, guilt, and claustrophobic overload	Holding cells, riots, corpse work, family pressure, witnessing a Cleaning	The character cracks: freeze, lash out, confess, or flee. Reset to 2 after the crisis.
Heat	How much attention the PCs have drawn	Forgery, camera exposure, bribery, repeated questions, embarrassing authority	Authority acts: raids, tails, arrests, or mandatory interviews. Reset to 2 once the response lands.
Fatigue	Physical depletion from stairs, hunger, injury, and overwork	Long climbs, skipped meals, poor sleep, carrying loads, labour shifts	The body gives out: collapse, tremor, dropped gear, slowed movement. Reset to 2 after rest or medical care.

31.3 Consequence Menu

On a mixed success or failure, choose one consequence that pushes play forward:

- **Time:** They get it done, but the scene runs long and another faction acts first.
- **Attention:** They succeed, but Heat rises or a witness remembers them.
- **Wear:** A tool breaks, clothing tears, or a precious consumable is spent.
- **Strain:** Stress or Fatigue rises because the cost was personal.
- **Debt:** Someone helps them and now expects repayment.
- **Damage:** The environment changes for the worse: blackout, leak, stampede, or lockdown.

31.4 Fail-Forward by Scene Type

- **Bureaucracy:** They get the form, but it is logged under their name.
- **Stealth:** They avoid immediate capture, but someone saw a silhouette, heard a voice, or finds evidence later.
- **Travel:** They arrive, but dehydrated, late, or missing a piece of gear.

- **Social Pressure:** They win the argument, but create a grudge, rumour, or compromise.
- **Repair Work:** The machine works for now, but only if fed more parts, more labour, or a dangerous workaround.

31.5 Escalation Clocks

When the PCs start meddling in a problem larger than a single room, create one 4-segment clock:

- **Authority Clock:** Fills when they leave evidence, anger officials, or show a pattern.
- **Neighbourhood Clock:** Fills when rumours spread, shortages worsen, or civilians panic.
- **Infrastructure Clock:** Fills when a leak, contamination, or power fault gets worse.

When a clock fills, something irreversible happens in the fiction. Do not only threaten; change the situation.

31.6 Downtime Between Crises

Between major scenes, each PC can usually do one meaningful thing:

- **Work the Shift:** Earn modest chits, but stay on someone's radar.
- **Lay Low:** Reduce Heat, but lose access to rumours and fast opportunities.
- **Scrounge:** Find a part, ration, or contact, but risk owing a favour.
- **Care for Someone:** Reduce that person's Stress or Fatigue and deepen the relationship.
- **Ask the Stairs:** Gather rumours through Porters, traders, and queue-lines.

Chapter 32: Faction Sheets

Use these when the PCs touch politics and survival at the same time.

Faction	Public Face	Real Objective	Primary Leverage	What They Want from PCs
IT	Efficient stewards of data and infrastructure	Preserve information monopolies and buried truths	Cameras, archives, access permissions, cold rooms	Deny them anomalies, recover stolen tech, carry sealed messages
Judicial	Guardians of order and the Pact	Keep fear abstract and obedience routine	Trials, disappearances, sealed warrants, informants	Names, leverage, quiet compliance, manufactured examples
Sheriff's Office	Visible law, public peace, crowd control	Prevent open chaos without learning too much	Deputies, patrols, legal force, local trust	Witnesses, calm streets, culprits easy to arrest
Mechanical	Proud labour backbone of the Silo	Keep the machine alive and protect their autonomy	Access to power, repairs, heavy labour, strategic sabotage	Honest warnings, spare parts, silence about unsafe realities
Supply	Neutral stewards of scarcity	Turn inventory into political power	Ledgers, stamps, rations, delays	Favours, signatures, selective shortages, deniable runners
Medical	Healers and birthkeepers	Manage bodies, fertility, and social stability	Drugs, diagnoses, records, quarantine authority	Samples, quiet patients, plausible paperwork
Porters' Union	Tireless runners of the stairs	Maintain neutrality and protect the flow of news	Speed, routes, gossip, discreet delivery	Respect, water, fair payment, noninterference

Faction	Public Face	Real Objective	Primary Leverage	What They Want from PCs
Scrap Syndicates	Not public at all	Profit from every shortage and weak point	Contraband, debt, intimidation, salvage crews	Future favours, silence, risky jobs
Flame Watchers	Spiritual weirdos and rumour-fodder	Keep hope alive even when hope is dangerous	Secret rooms, coded talk, believers, relic lore	Sympathy, cover, recruits, proof that the world is bigger

32.1 Reading a Faction Fast

If you need to improvise quickly, answer four questions:

1. What is this faction afraid of right now?
2. What are they short on?
3. Who would embarrass them if the truth came out?
4. What small thing can the PCs do that would make this faction temporarily useful?

Chapter 33: The Slice-of-Life Engine

These generators keep the campaign grounded in the daily grind before the big revelations.

33.1 Block Problems (d12)

Roll	Problem
1	A shared water line is giving only a brown trickle.
2	Someone is sleeping in the laundry room and stealing heat from the pipework.
3	A family from another level has been reassigned into an already crowded apartment.
4	The ration clerk's ledger does not match the actual grain sacks.

Roll	Problem
5	A dead body cannot be moved until paperwork arrives, and everyone has to live around it.
6	The hallway lights burn out and Supply says replacements are “pending”.
7	A child found something metallic in a wall cavity and refuses to say where.
8	A local deputy is shaking people down for “inspection fees”.
9	Mould creeps through an entire sleeping tier.
10	The floor’s unofficial fixer vanishes with everyone’s chit box.
11	A marriage permit is denied and both families blame each other.
12	A known Friend of the Silo suddenly starts acting frightened instead of smug.

33.2 Inspections and Sweeps (d10)

Roll	Trigger
1	A camera finally got repaired and immediately caught last week’s crime.
2	Supply reported impossible consumption numbers.
3	Someone talked too loudly after Pact Silence.
4	A black-market item surfaced in the wrong class of hands.
5	Judicial wants one arrest to remind the level who is in charge.
6	A deputy lost face publicly and wants revenge disguised as duty.
7	Medical flagged a cluster of sedative-resistant citizens.

Roll	Trigger
8	A Porter carried a message they were not supposed to read.
9	An air-scrubber fault provides perfect cover for a fishing expedition.
10	The inspection is fake; the real target is elsewhere on the level.

33.3 Favors People Ask of the PCs (d12)

Roll	Favour
1	Carry a message without reading it.
2	Sit with a dying relative so the family can work their shift.
3	Find out whether a deputy can be bribed.
4	Hide a forbidden object for one night only.
5	Smuggle fresh water to someone under quarantine.
6	Escort a child ten levels for a name-gifting ceremony.
7	Intimidate a landlord without making it look official.
8	Bring a Mechanical part to a doctor who should not have it.
9	Stand in a ration line for someone too injured to climb.
10	Recover a body before Judicial turns it into an example.
11	Deliver a forged form before dawn.
12	Learn whether a missing worker ran away, was arrested, or was selected as an informant.

33.4 Sudden Shortages (d10)

Roll	Shortage
1	Lamp oil
2	Filter cloth
3	Antibiotics
4	Rabbit feed
5	Rivets
6	Boiler sealant
7	Salt
8	Boots in common sizes
9	Clean bandages
10	Good heat tape

[END OF COMPREHENSIVE WORLD BIBLE]